



Nazca Lines

Monumental geometric designs and zoomorphic figures inscribed in the surface of the Peruvian desert

The coastal plain of the Rio Grande de Nazca in southern Peru is adorned by huge geoglyphs (designs and motifs created on the ground). They are the legacy of the Nazca civilization, which flourished between 500 BCE and 500 CE. Across a vast area of desert, the Nazca Lines were scratched out of the gravel surface over about 1,000 years, forming a unique collection of designs and images on such a large scale that they cannot be properly appreciated from ground level.

Scraping through

There are mainly two types of geoglyphs on the site. The first are the straight or curved lines: straight lines stretch for several miles across the desert, sometimes forming criss-cross patterns. They range in width from 20 in (50 cm) to 16 ft (5 m) and may have held some intrinsic ritual significance or connected sacred sites. Curved lines form geometric designs, such as curves, spirals, and wavy patterns.

The second group consists of stylized representations of natural forms. The few depictions of humans and inanimate objects are generally inscribed on hillsides around the plain.



CREATING THE NAZCA LINES

The lines were made possible by the contrasting colors of the dark, iron-oxide-coated stones on the desert floor and the much lighter earth beneath them. Simply scraping these pebbles from the surface was enough to create effectively permanent marks. A selection of the designs is shown here.



HERON
236 ft (72 m) long



LABYRINTH
236 ft (72 m) long



HANDS
170 ft (52 m) long



MONKEY
360 ft (110 m) long



OWL-MAN
131 ft (40 m) long



△ THE NAZCA SPIDER

This spider, when seen from above, shows the distinctive artistic style of the Nazca people and the astonishing accuracy with which it was rendered.

< HUMMINGBIRD TAIL

The tail feathers of the hummingbird figure are formed by a series of long parallel lines scratched into the desert surface.